While acknowledging that many people were infuriated by his act of mercy, Holmer's parish backed the move. 'Critics and demonstrators, of course, had a wide variety of arguments,' he explained. 'Most of the time they were annoyed, surprised, or angry that we were granting Honecker asylum. For us, the two were a helpless, rather desperate couple who found no other help than in a parsonage.' At Lobetal, another heartbreaking scene had played out after Sonya and Leo had been made redundant. That winter, the couple accepted an opportunity offered by UNHCR which was providing Chilean refugees free flights (and free excess baggage) to return home.

The farewell was emotional. Roberto remembered his grandparents were tense but full of composure. Sonja fretted over what was to become of her parents, especially her sick father. Their relocation, it transpired, added to Margot and Erich's anxiety as Sonja found herself in a bewildering and uncharted world. In letters to her parents, she complained about problems finding a job and her desire to return to Europe.

Meanwhile in the outside world, it was clear that progress toward a united Germany would quicken after multi-party elections in the GDR during March. After the polls, West Germany and the new East German government would talk about the path to unity. Chancellor Kohl – without any consultation with his allies – arrived in Russia in February and won agreement that 'the unity of the German nation must be decided by the Germans themselves'. From this point, nothing could halt reunification. On 13 February, the four Allied powers from the Second World War – Britain, France, the United States and the Soviet Union – agreed to talks on security issues and, in a speech to the Bundestag, Kohl heralded unification as imminent.

Meanwhile, in Bernau, protesters succeeded in hounding the Honeckers out of Holmer's vicarage during March. After frantic pleas to the Russians, the couple found shelter at a Soviet military hospital at Beelitz-Heilstätten, an overgrown Wilhelminian-era compound near Potsdam, sealed by a high wall. 'When we were brought here,' Honecker complained, 'we were only allowed to bring whatever we could carry. Our furniture and the bulk of our personal possessions is being looked after by friends in Berlin.'18